

- A FIELD MANUAL -

The PLAYBOOK

Field notes from ceremonies that solved nothing,
filed under names that should not have been printed.

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Chapter I.

Ceremonies

Four rituals investigated.
No blockers reported.
Everything blocked.

Case No. 001	RECURRING	Case No. 002	UNRESOLVED
The Sprint That Planned Itself		The Standup That Would Not End	
SUBJECT Sprint Planning		SUBJECT Daily Standup	
SYMPTOM "We'll figure out scope during the sprint."		SYMPTOM "Yesterday I... Today I... No blockers."	
DIAGNOSIS Jira / ADO filled with vague hopes and duplicate epics. Nobody names the outcome.		DIAGNOSIS Rote status ritual with no real signal. Team performs updates for the room, not the work.	
RECOMMENDATION Start with outcomes, not tickets. If nobody can state the goal, do not start the sprint.		RECOMMENDATION Ask: "What would unblock the team today?" Then let people leave.	
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	SPRINT ∞	FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	DAILY @ 9:00

Case No. 003	STAND	Case No. 004	IN REGRESSION
The Retro That Solved Nothing		The Demo That Demoed a Prototype of a Demo	
SUBJECT	Sprint Retrospective	SUBJECT	Sprint Demo
SYMPTOM	Complaints aired. Post-its written. Nothing changes by next sprint.	SYMPTOM	"Please imagine this is clickable."
DIAGNOSIS	Venting mistaken for progress. No owner assigned to any action.	DIAGNOSIS	PowerPoint pixels shown in place of shipped work. Team performs delivery.
RECOMMENDATION	Turn one vent into one action item every sprint. Name the owner before the meeting ends.	RECOMMENDATION	Show real value or say the truth. "We did not ship this sprint" is a valid demo.
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	END OF SPRINT	FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	FORTNIGHTLY

Chapter II.

Roles & Personas

Four archetypes at large.
Suspected of Agile theater
in varying degrees.

Case No. 005	CONFIDENTIAL	Case No. 006	SUSPECTED
The Voice That Forgot to Listen		The Master Who Forgot the Purpose	
SUBJECT	Product Owner	SUBJECT	Scrum Grandmaster
ALIAS	"Voice of the customer."	ALIAS	"Keeper of the ceremony."
DIAGNOSIS	Speaks for customers. Has not spoken to customers in six sprints.	DIAGNOSIS	Enforces every ritual. Cannot explain why any of them exist.
RECOMMENDATION	Schedule the customer call. Bring transcripts. Stop paraphrasing.	RECOMMENDATION	Ask what each ceremony is for. If the answer is "the framework," cancel it.
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	ONGOING	FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	RECURRING

Case No. 007	OPEN	Case No. 008	WITNESSED
The Lead Who Only Measured Delivery		The Stakeholder Who Joined Sprint Six	
SUBJECT	Delivery Lead	SUBJECT	Stakeholder X
ALIAS	"Gets things shipped."	ALIAS	"I have a small change."
DIAGNOSIS	Measures success only by shipping. Value shipped is not measured at all.	DIAGNOSIS	Absent through discovery. Present through re-scoping. Loud through delivery.
RECOMMENDATION	Add one outcome metric per initiative. Ship becomes shipped-and-used.	RECOMMENDATION	Publish the decision log. Late input is welcome; late overrides are not.
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	Q4	FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY	SPRINT 6

Chapter III.

Tools & Templates

Four artifacts recovered
from the scene. All still
in circulation.

Case No. 009	PRESERVED	Case No. 010	NEGLECTED
The Poster That Time Forgot		The Chart Nobody Read	
SUBJECT	Definition of Done	SUBJECT	Burndown Chart
CONDITION	Laminated. Last revised: pre-pandemic.	CONDITION	Exists. Only reviewed when things go wrong.
DIAGNOSIS	Written when the team was different. Referenced by no one. Enforced by silence.	DIAGNOSIS	Compliance artifact. Signal after the fact.
RECOMMENDATION	Rewrite it in the next refinement. Anything you do not defend, you should not display.	RECOMMENDATION	Delete it or use it. If you would stop reading it tomorrow and nothing would change, that is your answer.
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY WALL, THIRD FLOOR		FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY AUTO-GENERATED	

Case No. 011	MISAPPLIED	Case No. 012	IN PROGRESS
The Score That Was Not a Score		The Board That Never Moved	
SUBJECT	Velocity Metrics	SUBJECT	Agile Board (Jira / ADO)
CONDITION	Used to compare team happiness. Incorrectly.	CONDITION	78% of tickets in "In Progress" or "Blocked" purgatory.
DIAGNOSIS	Planning signal treated as performance metric. Teams inflate points to keep the number steady.	DIAGNOSIS	Board does not reflect the actual work. Standups happen anyway.
RECOMMENDATION	Use velocity for planning only. Never in a performance review. Ever.	RECOMMENDATION	Jira and ADO are not the source of truth. People are. Talk to the humans before you touch the board.
FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY DASHBOARD, TV LOBBY		FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY ALL QUARTERS	

Chapter IV • Findings

The Verdict.

Twelve cases reviewed. Four truths recovered. Filed under the only category that matters.

01

Jira / ADO is not the source of truth. **PEOPLE ARE.** If the board does not reflect reality, talk to the humans.

02

Velocity is not a performance metric. **IT IS A PLANNING SIGNAL, NOT A SCOREBOARD.**

03

You do not need more process. **YOU NEED MORE COURAGE.** Courage to speak clearly, say no, and show up human.

04

If you are never laughing, you are not doing it right. **SATIRE IS A SIGNAL.** It means we care enough to notice.

CHAPTER V • CLOSE OF FILE

Twelve cases. One standard.

The Playbook does not exist to make Agile prettier. It exists to help teams name the pattern before the pattern becomes culture.

Read the Manifesto and acknowledge receipt at fragileframework.com

Legal status: ceremonial. Emotional accuracy: unfortunately high.